# FARMLIFE

KCFB KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

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## State v. KCFB: What the Appellate Ruling Means for Groundwater Rights in Kings County

By Dusty Ference, Executive Director, Kings County Farm Bureau

In a major legal battle that could shape the future of groundwater regulation across California, the Kings County Farm Bureau (KCFB) is continuing its challenge against the State Water Resources Control Board (SWRCB). The core of the dispute focuses on how and whether the State can override local groundwater management in the name of complying with the Sustainable Groundwater Management Act (SGMA).

On October 29, 2025, the Fifth District Court of Appeal issued its long-awaited decision in State Water Resources Control Board v. Kings County Superior Court. While the appellate court sided with the State on several procedural points, the ruling preserved most of our case. Crucially, our core SGMA claims, those focused on State overreach, local control, and due process, remain active and will now proceed to trial in Kings County Superior Court.

This article breaks down what the ruling means, what's still in play, and why this case matters far beyond Kings County.

### Background: How We Got Here

In April 2024, the State Water Board declared the Tulare Lake Subbasin "probationary" under SGMA. This designation triggered immediate requirements for landowners and agencies, including well registration, metering, water-use reporting, and steep per-acre-foot extraction fees. It also opened the door to direct State control of groundwater allocations if local plans weren't deemed sufficient.

Within weeks, KCFB, along with two local landowners, filed a lawsuit challenging the legality of the State's actions. We alleged that the Board had overstepped its statutory authority, failed to provide proper notice, and ignored SGMA's own safeguards for compliant local agencies. The lawsuit raised nine causes of action, including constitutional and administrative law claims.

In September 2024, Kings County Superior Court issued a preliminary injunction halting enforcement of the State's probation-related requirements, effectively freezing the Board's mandates while the case moved forward. The court also ruled on the State's attempt to dismiss parts of our lawsuit. The judge dismissed one cause of action (an equal protection claim) but allowed the other eight to proceed.

That's when the State appealed.

### What the Appeals Court Ruled

The appellate court issued two decisions in October 2025; one focused specifically on three of our causes of action and another on the preliminary injunction. The three causes of action on appeal were:

1. That the State Board adopted "underground regulations"


*Lawsuit Update continued on page 8*


## Leading with service: Mello and Robinson earn KCFB's top honor

By Liza Robertson

This year's Kings County Farm Bureau (KCFB) President's Award recipients, Chip Mello and Sheriff David Robinson, are being honored for their servant leadership resulting in the betterment of the local agricultural community. The awardees were selected by Shane Bickner, who completed his two-year term as KCFB president in October.

"I admire the work and tremendous amount of time and effort they have dedicated as servant leaders to meet the needs and expectations of their roles," said Bickner. "Neither one of these guys have easy positions and I'm honored to present them with the President's Award this year."

### Chip Mello

Bickner selected Mello for his leadership in a time when the Sustainable Groundwater Management Act (SGMA) is creating challenges and uncertainty for producers. Mello assumed the role of president of the Kings County Water District (KCWD) last winter after serving several months as a director.

"Chip has taken on a big responsibility by volunteering time away from family and work in a climate when emotions could not be higher," said Bickner. "It's not easy to step into that role right now and it takes a lot of courage to do that."

The position calls for Mello to navigate complex issues while considering the immense responsibility of leading the KCWD, whose job it is to deliver water to users.

"There are a lot of water policies that have existed for a long time and I think it's important to create policies that make it more convenient for everyone to get their fair share of water," said Mello. "There are some people who haven't received surface water in the past and who are going to want that in the future. I think it's important to think about how we can make that happen."

Mello, who farms in Hanford with his father, has been an active participant in issues related to water. He understands the history of water rights in the area and the varied and often complicated needs of growers in the county.

"Our farm was started by my grandfather, and has been in the family for a long time," said Mello. "We grow a variety


*Presidents's Award continued on page 14*

KCFB
KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

**Purpose**
Protect, preserve and enhance agriculture in Kings County

**Vision**
Ensure that every farmer has the right to farm and protect their heritage

**Values**
Our Members | Proactive Representative
Reliable | Trusted Resource

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## KCFB Executive Director's Report

# 2024 Economic Impact

*Dusty Ference*

If you ever needed proof that agriculture is the backbone of Kings County, here it is. The new Economic Impact Report, developed with our partners at Kings EDC, shows that agriculture isn't just holding steady—it's driving our local economy.

Agriculture accounts for $1.1 billion of the county's $7.7 billion GDP and supports more than 8,000 local jobs. Additionally, ag wages average over $65,000 a year—about 13% above the countywide average. For every job in agriculture, nearly one and a half more are created in other parts of the economy.

Those dollars ripple through our community—funding schools, supporting fire departments, and keeping local businesses thriving. When agriculture thrives, so does Kings County. Reports like this remind us why KCFB's work matters: protecting, promoting, and defending the industry that sustains us all.

If you thought farming in Kings County was a quiet affair, the 2024 Crop Report says otherwise. Behind every acre, bale, and bucket of milk is a running battle with pests, the weather, and the laws of economics. It's part science, part patience, and part luck, and this year's numbers prove that local agriculture still has grit.

Kings County's farms and ranches produced more than $2.4 billion worth of crops and livestock in 2024, up from $2.15 billion the year before. Milk continues to hold the title of top earner, pouring in more than $812 million in value. Pistachios took second with $289 million, and cattle came next at $227 million. Add in cotton, processed tomatoes, almonds, and a few million dollars' worth of silage corn, and you've got the backbone of the county's economy. The numbers tell the story, but the side notes tell the fun parts.

Take cotton, for example. A crop many thought was fading is making a slow comeback. Pima cotton fetched $757 a bale last year, proof that Kings County still knows how to grow the good stuff. Silage corn and triticale quietly did their part too, together feeding the dairy industry that powers nearly a third of the county's entire agricultural value.

And then there's the other side of the ledger, the bugs, weeds, and critters that keep ag commissioners up at night. Kings County's team runs more than 1,300 traps year-round, hunting for invasive species before they can dig in. They're watching for everything from the Glassy-Winged Sharpshooter to the Melon Fruit Fly. When these pests show up, CDFA and county inspectors launch into action, setting traps, testing, and occasionally spraying before things get out of hand.

Sometimes, though, the invaders aren't insects. The latest unwanted visitor is Nutria, a 20-pound semi-aquatic rodent from South America with a talent for chewing through levees, vegetation, and sleep schedules. Two Nutria were spotted in Kings County in 2025, and the response was swift. Game cameras, traps, and monitoring are now in place to make sure this mud-eating menace doesn't find a new home in our canals. Given what it did to Louisiana's marshlands, nobody wants to see it get comfortable here.

The report also reminds us how closely farming and weather dance together. After 2023's big rain year of 12.7 inches, 2024 came in closer to average at 10 inches flat. In Kings County, "average" rain is a gift, it means steady planting windows and fewer panic moments with pump valves. No floods, no dust storms, just the kind of season farmers can actually plan around.

Amid the numbers are quirks that show how farming evolves. The county has nearly 60,000 registered organic acres, up significantly from just a few years ago. Over 147 growers and processors now operate under the organic label, proof that consumers and farmers are finding common ground between tradition and trend. And if you think that's a lot of paperwork, you'd be right. The county issued 1,939 export certificates last year to ship everything from alfalfa to almonds to China, India, and Vietnam.

Put it all together and you get a picture of a county that's not just growing food, it's constantly adapting. Every trap, trench, and acre tells a story of hard work and tight margins in a world where the pests never sleep and the markets never stop moving. The 2024 Crop Report is filled with numbers, yes, but between the lines you can see what really makes Kings County tick: a lot of smarts, a lot of grit, and just enough rain to keep the story going.

KCFB

KINGS edc

# ECONOMIC IMPACT REPORT 2024

## INTRODUCTION

Kings County agriculture remains a vital part of the local economy, fueling growth, creating jobs, and supporting community investment. This report emphasizes agriculture's contribution to the county's $7.7 billion GDP, its above-average wages, and its ripple effect across various industries. From supporting over 8,000 jobs to generating millions in property taxes, agriculture continues to anchor Kings County's economic stability and future growth.

## AVERAGE ANNUAL WAGES FOR AG

**$65,644**[1]

**AVERAGE ANNUAL ALL INDUSTRIES**
**$58,005**[1]

**AGRICULTURE WAGES ARE**
**13.2%**
Higher than the average in Kings County

## AG PAYS APPROXIMATELY $44.3 MILLION IN PROPERTY TAXES EACH YEAR[2]

- **22.65%** to the County, Fire Department, & Libraries
- **13.94%** to Rural Development Agency
- **6.19%** to the Cities
- **6.09%** to Special Districts

## MULTIPLIER FOR EMPLOYMENT

**1.47**[1]
Indirect and Induced Job Creation

For every job in agriculture, about one and a half more jobs are created in other parts of the economy.

## JOBS TOTAL IN AG

**8,139**[1]

**JOB TOTAL ALL INDUSTRIES 53,281**[1]

AG makes up aproximately **15%**

1 Source: JobsEQ®, http://www.chmuraecon.com/jobseq
2 Kings County Assessor's Office
Annual Wages, 2024 Q4. Employment 2024 Q4. Economic Impact-Multiplier 2024 Q4; GDP 2023.

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### Pump Efficiency Testing

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- Available regardless of acreage or farm size.

## Program Eligibility

To qualify for WELLUP submit an intake form.

## Who can apply?

Farmers and producers in Fresno, Kings, and Tulare Counties.

Special incentives are available for Socially Disadvantaged Farmers & Ranchers (SDFR).

**ekrcd.org** **Call us at: 559.309.4030**

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## 2025 Harvest Classic Tournament Winners

**1ST PLACE:**
Stone Land Company

**2ND PLACE:**
Hansen Bickner Farms

**3RD PLACE:**
Verdegaal Brothers

**LAST PLACE:**
Merrill Lynch

**LONGEST DRIVE:**
Brayden Sanchez

**GUESS YOUR YARDAGE:**
Zac Tate

**CLOSEST TO THE PIN:**
Brayden Sanchez,
Kristen Virden

## Thank you to our volunteers

Jimmy Hook
Mario Gutierrez
Kris Costa
RJ Trevino
Patrick Abraham
Isaiah Hernandez
Jose Valadez

## Thank you to our Harvest Classic Committee

Jordan Bickner
Patrick O'Connor
Brian Medeiros

*First Place: Stone Land Company*

*Second Place: Hansen Bickner Farms*

*Guess Your Yardage: Zac Tate*

*Last Place: Merrill Lynch*

*Closest to the Pin:*
*Brayden Sanchez, Kristen Virden*

# SGMA DEFENSE FUND

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# The Drafts Are In: Groundwater Allocations Arrive for Mid-Kings and South Fork Kings

by Julie Martella

**What's in the plans, who's affected, and what's still in motion across the Tulare Lake Subbasin.**

The question isn't *if* groundwater pumping will be limited. It's *how much, when,* and *for whom*. That question just got a lot more real.

In mid-October, the Mid-Kings River and South Fork Kings GSAs, officially approved draft groundwater allocation plans and opened a 45-day public review period. These are not conceptual documents; they are the first concrete frameworks for how water use will be managed in this basin moving forward. If you're a landowner, operator, or well user, your voice now matters more than ever.

These plans mark the beginning of a new chapter not just for the GSAs, but for everyone who relies on groundwater in the Tulare Lake Subbasin.

Each plan lays out how pumping will be reduced between now and 2040, what's allowed under transitional use (a temporary water allowance usable during the transition to sustainable yield), and how water can be managed at the farm level. They also begin to answer the long-standing question: *How will these rules apply to me?*

## Core Details from the Drafts

At a high level, the two draft plans are closely aligned.

Mid-Kings River's plan allocates Sustainable Yield at 1.43 acre-feet per acre (AF/acre) per year. On top of that, landowners will initially receive 1.0 AF/acre of transitional water, which will phase out by 2040. That transitional water is not transferable, not renewable, and will be reduced first in areas where undesirable results, like subsidence, are already occurring.

Both GSAs allow for water to be applied to multiple parcels within a single farm unit, even across GSA boundaries, as long as those parcels are in compliance and meet all eligibility requirements. This farm-level flexibility could be a vital tool for producers managing complex operations across different jurisdictions.

Allocations will be distributed in five-year periods to provide more predictability for planning and investment. Any unused Sustainable Yield can be carried over for up to five years.

The public comment period is now open. Both GSAs are inviting feedback through online forms, direct email, and public meetings. You can review the draft plans and submit your comments at:

- Mid-Kings River GSA: https://www.midkingsrivergsa.org/
- South Fork Kings GSA: https://southforkkings.org/

## What It Means for Stakeholders

These draft plans are more than technical documents. They're the first real step toward implementation. If you're a groundwater user in either GSA, now is the time to understand what's in the plan and how it applies to your land.

The drafts define how much groundwater you'll be allowed to use, how long transitional flexibility will last, and what rules apply if you operate across multiple parcels or GSAs. They also signal a shift: the era of untracked, **unlimited pumping is ending.**

This is not a drill. Allocations are being finalized. Enforcement and fee structures are upcoming.

*SGMA Update continued on page 11*

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# Ag Commissioner's Compliance Report

Jimmy Hook, Agricultural Commissioner/Sealer

## Pesticide Permit Renewal

The Kings County Agricultural Commissioner is now accepting Restricted Material Permit maps for 2026. We will begin issuing renewed pesticide permits on November 3, 2025. Permittees' paperwork may be emailed to noi@co.kings.ca.us or dropped off at anytime during business hours Monday – Friday, 8:00 AM – 5:00 PM. The office will notify the growers by telephone when the permit is ready to be picked up.

It is very important to provide new complete crop maps annually that include a description of the surrounding area. These maps should include the surrounding crops, residential areas, schools, hospitals, canals/ditches, parks, playgrounds, and livestock. Any changes in the growers crops or sites should also be submitted with the maps. These detailed crop maps allow the county inspectors to properly assess each site to locate any potential effects an application might have on people and the local environment and are used to ensure compliance with laws, regulations, and permit conditions. These same maps may end up being used in the field by pest control advisors (PCAs) and operators (PCOs), as well as Agricultural Commissioner staff, so detail is important!

During this time, we will also be renewing Private Applicator Certificates that expire on December 31, 2025. Private applicators are required to have 2 hours of continuing education for every year their card is valid. If you need any hours, we have four classes still available this year. October 22nd and November 12th from 6pm – 8pm, and December 3rd and 17th from 9am – 11am. You can sign up for those by calling our office, each class is $10. If you need to take the Private Applicator Certificate or the Burrowing Vertebrate Rodent exam, please contact our office to schedule a day and time. We are currently scheduling these on Wednesdays.

The Commissioner will be offering pesticide safety training for employees who handle pesticides. These sessions will be offered on January 21st and 22nd and March 11th and 12th of 2026. Both English and Spanish sessions will take place. The cost is $10 per session and satisfies the general training requirement of the California Code of Regulations. Please call to sign up your employees.

This is also the time that the Kings County Agricultural Commissioner is compiling our annual crop and livestock report statistics. Every year we send out a questionnaire with the permit renewal letter asking growers for their average production and price of the harvested crops from that year. The annual crop and livestock report is useful to many people including growers, schools, banks, and many other institutions. The information, which only you can provide, helps to promote the agricultural industry of Kings County. The office needs your input in order to compile an accurate report. Please be assured that any information you provide will be handled in the strictest confidential manner. No information is shared with any other agencies. Your data will be averaged with all data received from other growers of the same commodity from throughout the county. We would greatly appreciate it if you would please take the time to compile the questionnaire and return it to our office within the next few weeks.

If you have any questions regarding the above information, please call (559) 852-2830

*Lawsuit Update continued from page 1*

without going through the required public rulemaking process;

2. That its $20-per-acre-foot groundwater fee was an unconstitutional tax; and

3. That the Farm Bureau could pursue broad declaratory relief challenging the legality of the entire probationary designation process.

On the first cause of action, the court ruled that SGMA explicitly exempts the SWRCB from California's Administrative Procedure Act (APA) when taking actions under its probationary authority. In short, the court held that even if the Board's probation process resembles a regulation, it doesn't have to follow APA procedures unless it voluntarily chooses to do so.

On the second cause of action, the appellate court did not determine whether the fee was unlawful, but only determined it was subject to the "pay first, sue later" rule under California law. Since no fees had yet been paid, the court concluded the Farm Bureau couldn't proceed with that claim at this time.

The decision also struck our broad declaratory relief claim as duplicative of the other, more specific claims in the suit.

### Remand on the Preliminary Injunction

The court of appeal set aside the preliminary injunction but left the door open for the trial court to consider whether it would reissue the preliminary injunction, modify the preliminary injunction, or decline to issue it at this time. Importantly, the court of appeals agreed that the State Water Board acted unlawfully when it failed to consider the good actor clause and whether to exclude parts of the subbasin that were sustainable from probation. This is a critical issue and a win for local control.

### What Remains and Why It Matters

Despite this partial setback, our key claims, those focused on the actual merits of the State's actions, are still alive:

- Overreach: We argue the State Board acted beyond its statutory authority under SGMA by bypassing key steps and directly imposing requirements on local agencies without legal basis.
- Good Actor Provision: SGMA includes a "good actor" clause that protects agencies implementing valid plans. The Board refused to apply this clause to any part of the Tulare Lake Subbasin, a move we contend violates both the statute and legislative intent.
- Lack of Notice: The State failed to give landowners timely, meaningful notice before imposing new groundwater obligations, raising serious due process concerns.
- Arbitrary Designation: We believe the Board's finding that our basin's sustainability plan was "deficient" lacked sufficient evidence and failed to consider local conditions and ongoing improvements.

These are not technical or procedural points. They go to the very heart of how SGMA is supposed to work: as a law designed to prioritize local management first, with state oversight only as a last resort. If the State can impose sweeping mandates without meaningful review, it sets a precedent that threatens growers across California.

### What Happens Next

Now that the appellate court has ruled, the case returns to Kings County Superior Court. We anticipate a hearing on the remaining claims in the coming months.

In the meantime, our Board of Directors is reviewing all available legal options, including actions beyond the trial court process. We will keep our members, supporters, and community informed throughout this important phase.

### Final Thoughts

This case isn't only about fees, forms, or groundwater models. It's about protecting the voice of local agriculture in decisions that impact our land, water, and way of life. KCFB remains dedicated to defending the rights of our farmers, ranchers, and local groundwater agencies. We appreciate the ongoing support of our SGMA Defense donors and the broader agriculture community.

Whether you manage 40 acres or 4,000, or work for a business in town, this issue affects us all. As we approach trial, we'll keep fighting for a groundwater policy that's fair, lawful, and locally driven.

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ANNUAL
MEETING

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Join us for the Kings County Farm Bureau Annual Meeting as we look back on the year's achievements, celebrate our dedicated members, and enjoy an exciting live auction! We'll also honor outgoing President Shane Bickner for his service and welcome our new slate of officers.

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*SGMA Update continued from page 7*

### Not Everyone Will Be Impacted

If you are a domestic well owner and pump less than 2 acre-feet of water per year for domestic purposes only, you are considered a de minimis user under California law. That means you are exempt from this allocation policy. You do not need to track or report pumping, and your well is not subject to the same groundwater restrictions being proposed for larger agricultural users. However, you are still encouraged to register your well so that you're eligible for any future mitigation or assistance programs.

### What's Still Being Worked Out

Despite the milestone of releasing these draft plans, several key policy issues remain in motion:

- **Baseline Year for Subsidence:** South Fork Kings and Mid-Kings have discussed whether 2020 or 2023 should be used as the "baseline year" for tracking future land subsidence. Many stakeholders, particularly those who experienced subsidence early, have urged GSAs to lock in 2020 to preserve consistency and accountability. No final decision has been made.
- **Domestic Well Mitigation Program Rollout:** Pilot well replacements have begun in Mid-Kings River. South Fork Kings is refining its program. Both GSAs are tying eligibility to well registration and compliance history.
- **Prop 218 Election Planning:** Each GSA is preparing for upcoming hearings to determine how groundwater-related fees will be structured and collected. These decisions will determine who pays, how much, and under what legal authority.
- **Well Registration Portals:** Mid-Kings has approved a contract to build an online portal for well registration. This portal will be central to compliance and communication moving forward. South Fork Kings is working to register their remaining wells.

### Tri-County Water Authority

Tri-County's Stakeholder Advisory Committee met on September 24. While a draft allocation plan has not yet been publicly released, the GSA is working to revise its GSP and coordinate subsidence thresholds across the basin. The tone in Tri County remains collaborative, with consistent focus on data, coordination, and planning ahead.

### Southwest Kings & El Rico

Neither GSA held a board meeting in September. El Rico is still finalizing its subsidence threshold values before finalizing and participating in basin-wide discussions.

### What You Can Do and Why It Matters

Both Mid-Kings River and South Fork Kings GSAs are now accepting public comments on their draft allocation plans through December 1. During these 45 days, each GSA will host at least one in-person and one virtual workshop open to the public. These sessions will explain the draft, answer questions, and gather meaningful feedback before finalizing the draft document.

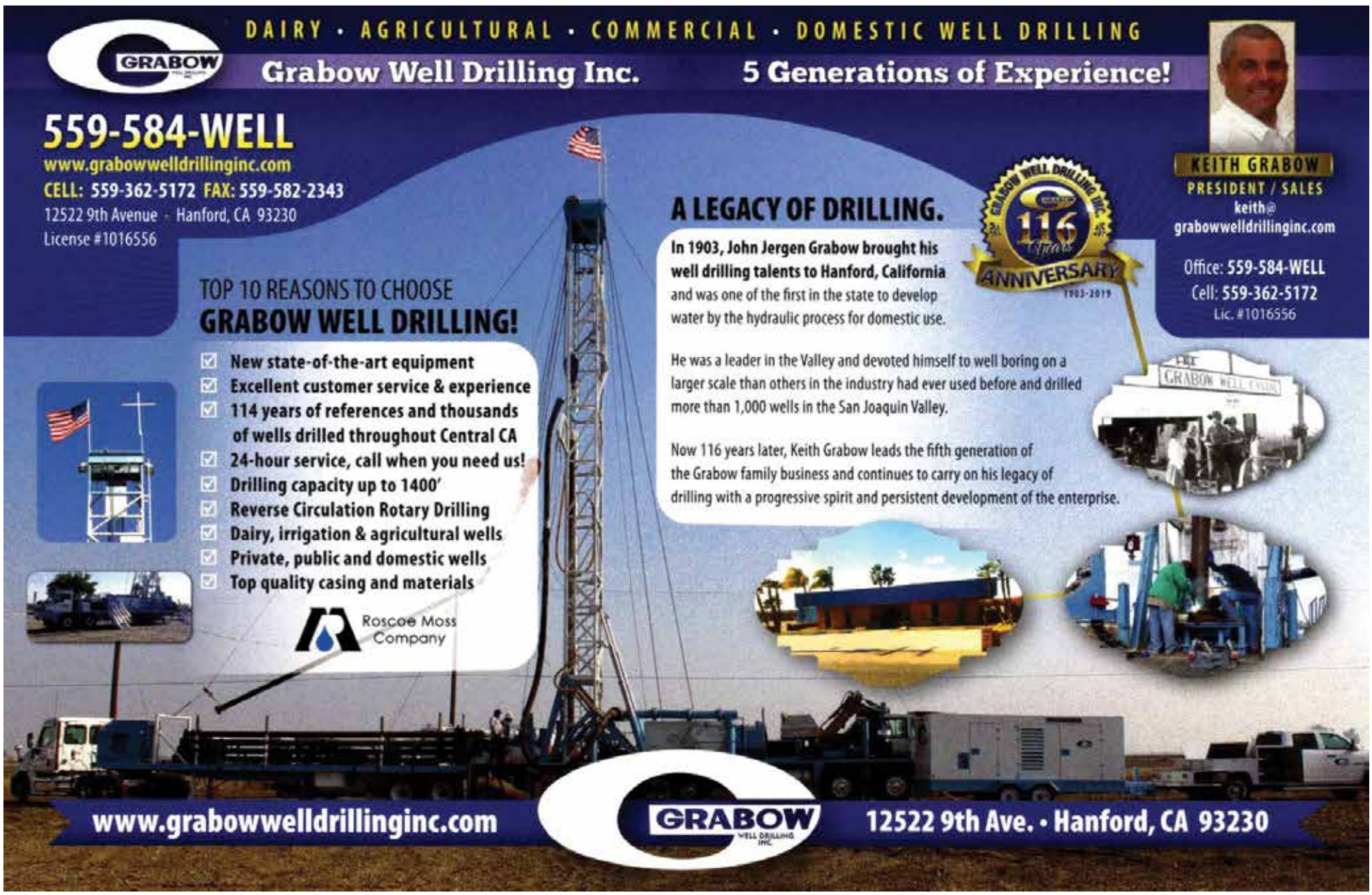
Whether you operate a large farm, manage a few acres, or rely on a domestic well, this is your opportunity to weigh in before the rules are adopted.

Here's how to take part:

- **Read the Draft Plan** for your GSA to understand what's proposed
- **Submit a Public Comment** either online, by email, or via the QR codes.
- **Attend a Workshop** to ask questions and hear community perspectives
- **Register Your Well**, even if you're a de minimis user, to stay eligible for future notifications or resources
- **Stay Informed** by following your GSA on social media or subscribing to email updates

If you've been waiting for the dust to settle, this is the moment to pay attention.

The policies being developed now will shape how much water you can use, how flexibility is managed, and how local control is preserved. Your input won't just be heard; it could influence the final document.



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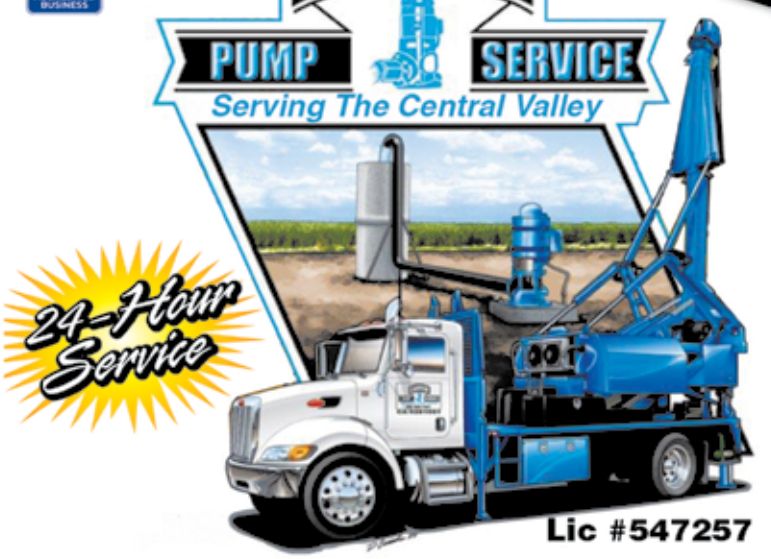


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# Pruning Roses for Healthier Blooms

Contributed by Haramrit Gill, PhD, Environmental Horticulture Advisor, UCCE Tulare County

Pruning roses is an essential task for gardeners looking to maximize the health and beauty of their plants. While it can seem like a daunting task, when done correctly, it encourages robust growth, vibrant blooms, and minimizes the risks of pests and diseases. In regions like the Central Valley, where the climate is ideal for roses, proper pruning becomes even more important to help plants thrive in the long term. The best time to prune roses in the Central Valley is during late winter to early spring—typically between late January and March—before the growing season begins. This timing allows you to remove any dead or diseased wood, shape the plant, and promote the healthiest new growth. Pruning during dormancy gives the plant time to heal and redirect energy into strong, productive growth once the warmer weather arrives.

Before you start, make sure you have the right tools. Sharp pruning shears are essential for most cuts, while loppers are useful for thicker stems. Protect your hands with sturdy gloves to avoid injury from sharp thorns. Start by inspecting your rose bush for dead, damaged, or diseased wood, and remove it first. Any stems that appear discolored, brittle, or shriveled should be cut back to healthy tissue. Always cut just above a healthy bud or leaf node, as this encourages new growth from the cut point. Once you've dealt with damaged wood, focus on the shape of the plant. For most rose varieties, an open center is ideal, as it allows for better air circulation and sunlight exposure. Cut away any branches that grow inward or cross over each other. This helps maintain a clean, open framework that will support healthy growth and prevent disease buildup. Additionally, prune any long, weak stems that might be struggling to grow. Cutting them back to a strong, outward-facing bud ensures that the plant puts its energy into creating sturdy stems and vibrant blooms.

When pruning bush roses, aim to cut back about one-third to one-half of the plant's total height. This may seem like a significant reduction, but it's necessary for encouraging vigorous growth and a bountiful flower display. For climbing and rambling roses, prune only the spent blooms and thin out older wood. This type of rose benefits from less intensive pruning, as they flower on the previous year's growth.

It's important to avoid common mistakes when pruning roses. Pruning too early in the winter can expose the plant to frost damage, while pruning too late may risk removing buds that could have bloomed in spring. Additionally, over-pruning can weaken the plant and limit its ability to produce new growth. Always be mindful of the plant's structure and only remove what's necessary. After pruning, clear away any fallen debris from the base of the plant to prevent the spread of pests and disease. Proper disposal of cuttings is essential to maintain a healthy garden.

*Presidents's Award continued from page 1*

of crops that require different water requirements. That helps me understand where growers are coming from in regards to what they need and when they need it."

With SGMA reducing the amount of groundwater farmers can pump, surface water is becoming more valuable to all growers. Mello noted that coordinating growers' needs with river flows and considering long-standing approaches is crucial. While SGMA threatens to change what the future looks like for the area, he understands the significance of ensuring growers know what to expect.

"Creating some protocols to make sure people can at least plan for their future is very important," said Mello. "Trying to create rules that are equitable for everyone has been a main concern—it's incredibly impactful and people have a lot of uncertainty."

Mello said that with so many variables in the regulation, now is an important time for farmers to get involved and have their voices heard.

"We have a lot of good people in the community and a very diverse group in the ag industry," he said. "From small water users to large farmers and the variety of crops they grow, everyone has a very different and unique situation, and if they don't speak up, nobody's going to understand what's needed to accommodate every situation."

Bickner says Mello is someone people know they can count on.

"Chip is putting a lot of thought and care into the water matters that affect us," he said. "SGMA is essentially going to alter the landscape for the next 50 to 100 years, so it's important to have someone you can trust in a role like this. I know without a doubt we can trust Chip and he's going to make the right decisions on everyone's behalf."

As a leader, Mello knows he needs to carefully consider what everyone has to say.

"Learning how to be a good listener and making sure people know they are being heard is very important," he said. "My parents gave me a template to follow in life: speak the truth and treat everyone respectfully. It's just the way I was raised."

As a Farm Bureau member, Mello understands the weight of uniting individuals and industry groups.

"We've been members for a long time and I'm supportive of what Farm Bureau is doing because it's very much needed right now," he said. "More than anything, we need to figure out how to be unified in a lot of these issues because the power comes from a large group of people coming together. Without the unity, I don't think you have power or true influence on anything."

Bickner respects Mello's determination and commitment to the community.

"Chip has been dedicated to leading in a time of uncertainty as we're facing a new world with SGMA," he added. "We don't know what the future holds for our careers and our industry, and stepping up right now speaks volumes about his character."

Mello was surprised to hear he had been selected as a recipient of the President's Award.

"I didn't sign up for this thinking I was going to win any awards," he said. "I took on the role to try to make an impact and serve as best I can. It's an honor to have the community's backing and support."

### Sheriff David Robinson

It's Robinson's leadership style and ability to manage the Sheriff's Office in a way that not only helps farmers, but the whole community, that led Bickner to choose him as a President's Award recipient. The sheriff has personally attended board meetings and special events and has been receptive to issues that are important to KCFB and its members.

"I've always been impressed that nothing ever got out of control in his tenure," said Bickner. "He's been a servant leader who's been reachable and an advocate of people's rights. He's upheld the law very fairly and I admire him for that."

As an ally for farmers, Robinson has been a sheriff people know they can call on. KCFB has valued a good working relationship with him and Bickner emphasized the sheriff has always been a phone call away, no matter how big or small the issue.

"My best advice to leaders is you have to be available and you have to communicate," said Robinson. "I've always tried to be available to everyone by cellphone to make sure that if something's going on, they know they can call me."

Robinson, who grew up in Kings County, has an appreciation for agriculture that originated in his childhood.

"I have a lot of friends and family who live and work in the farming community," he said. "It's ingrained in me how much of an impact farming has on our lives. It was my upbringing that really painted that picture for me of knowing the importance of where our food grows and how the community comes together around that."

Robinson has been committed to maintaining the Rural Crime Task Force. When he became sheriff, he was immediately faced with the effects of the recession and countywide budget cuts. In partnership with KCFB, he presented the benefits of having a dedicated task force for ag crimes to the Board of Supervisors.

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# Kings County Rural Crime Report

Contributed by Detective Santos

In the month of October, the Rural Crimes Unit had a slower month, which overall is good for the community. We investigated the theft of copper wire from an oil pump "pumpjack" in the area of 25th Ave and Utica Ave in the Kettleman City hills. The suspect took approximately 450 feet of wire for a total loss of approximately $10,000.

During our wire theft investigation, we identified another wire theft suspect (not involved in the case above) who was recycling wire in Kings County but was determined to be stealing it from PG&E in Fresno County. This information was passed on to Chevron and Fresno County Ag Detectives.

We continuously monitor the amounts of copper wire recycled in Kings County and identified a person of interest. During this investigation the Rural Crimes Unit was able to verify this subject had stolen wire from multiple Ag pumps and businesses in Fresno County. We were able to identify the suspect and the pickup truck being used to commit the crimes. We also identified the location of the mini storage unit where the suspect was storing the stolen wire at, prior to recycling it, in Kings County. This information was given to Fresno County Ag Detectives, and an arrest was made by Fresno County with our assistance. A total of over 1000 pounds of stolen wire was recovered.

The Rural Crimes Unit assisted the California Department of Fish and Wildlife with the eradication of nearly 600 marijuana plants in the area of 19th Ave and Kansas Ave in Lemoore. We would also like to ask the community if you are aware of any illegal marijuana weed grows in the county to reach out to one of the Rural Crimes Unit members and provide us with the details. The Rural Crimes Unit and Department of Fish and Wildlife are working closely together to eradicate any illegal weed grows.

If you have any questions, feel free to call me or any of our unit members at any time.

**Detective Santos (559) 904-6893**
**Detective Estrada (559) 212-7512**
**Investigator Ward (559) 280-5441**

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"With the Farm Bureau's support, I was able to present a full picture of what the task force meant for the community and the Central Valley," said Robinson. "The board understood the significance and the topic of funding has never come up again."

Robinson also recalls nearly a decade ago, in one year alone, more than $1 million of stolen agriculture equipment was recovered by his task force.

"The Rural Crime Task Force did a fantastic job of returning the property to the owners," he added. "I'm really proud of that. We've had such a strong presence and have connected with farmers so they know what we're working on. The Farm Bureau has played an important part in building and maintaining that connection."

After almost 15 years, Robinson will retire in November as one of Kings County's longest-serving sheriffs. During his tenure, he has worked to expand the presence of his office.

"It's important that the Sheriff's Office is very well represented," said Bickner. "Especially in the past two years, there has been so much theft and abnormal disruptions and the sheriff has been very responsive and sympathetic to everything that has transpired. Whether it's through the addition of a plane or helicopter, it was important that he continued building up the presence of deputies in the community."

Robinson has made investments, including in air support, that have greatly expanded the capabilities of the office. The Sheriff's Office now operates two airplanes and a helicopter. The Air Support Unit assists ground-based law enforcement personnel engaged in all facets of law enforcement activities.

Robinson also points to legislative efforts made by his office that have benefited the ag community.

"With assistance from local farmers and the Kings County Farm Bureau, we were able to put together a copper wire theft bill that focuses on possession," said Robinson. "It's still alive and coming back with some real traction. We also got a bill amended where if you carry a gun in your vehicle, it can be in a locked toolbox. That legislative work had a real impact on our farming community."

Throughout his career as sheriff, Robinson has made it a priority to maintain a strong connection to ag and Farm Bureau, and for that, Bickner is grateful.

"Sheriff Robinson has done a really good job serving the community and we've been able to call on him whenever we need his input or support," said Bickner. "I admire his dedication to our community for all these years. He has truly exemplified servant leadership during his tenure and leaves a model for us to follow as we continue our partnership with the Sheriff's Office."

Mello and Robinson will be honored at KCFB's annual meeting on Nov. 20 at Tachi Palace Hotel & Casino. Tickets may be purchased at kcfb.org/events or by visiting the KCFB office.

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